

Major Incident Communication Plan

Purpose

Define the communication roles, channels, cadence, and templates used during a Summit IT P1 Major Incident. This plan works in conjunction with the technical response process in RUN-007. The goal is to ensure that stakeholders receive timely, accurate, consistent updates while the technical team focuses on resolution - without becoming a communication bottleneck.

Guiding Principles

1. **Communicate early, even if you don't have answers.** Silence is worse than "we are investigating."
2. **One source of truth.** All updates go through the Communications Lead. Technical staff do not communicate directly to stakeholders during a P1 unless explicitly directed by the IC.
3. **Status page is authoritative for users.** Direct users to <https://status.summitit.com> rather than providing piecemeal updates.
4. **Accuracy over speed for root cause.** Provide a preliminary root cause only when confirmed. Do not speculate in external communications.

Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Filled By	Responsibilities
Incident Commander (IC)	L2 Lead or L3 On-Call Engineer	Owns the incident; approves all significant communications; makes go/no-go decisions
Communications Lead	Designated L2 or Senior L1 on the bridge call	Drafts and sends all stakeholder communications; updates status page; monitors Slack/email for user questions; reports to IC
Technical Lead	L3 Engineer	Provides factual updates to Communications Lead on investigation status and ETA to fix; does not communicate externally

Scribe	Junior L2 or L1	Logs all actions, decisions, and timestamps in the INC ticket in real time
IT Director	Gretchen Holloway	Notified at T+15 min; escalation point if IC needs authority for major decisions; manages exec stakeholder comms
CISO	Nathan Burkett	Notified immediately for any security-related P1; owns all security-specific external communication

Communication Channels

Channel	Audience	Used For
Slack #it-major-incidents	IT staff	Internal incident bridge; technical updates; team coordination
Slack #it-help	All staff	Awareness of the issue; do not post technical details
Slack #announcements	All staff	Formal user-facing updates (sparingly - do not over-post)
SummitDesk ticket (INC-#####)	IT staff	Full incident log; all technical details; timestamped updates
Summit IT Status Page (https://status.summitit.com)	All users + external	Authoritative service status; updated every 30-60 minutes during incident
Email (all-staff or affected group)	All staff / affected group	For extended outages (>2 hours); do not email for short outages
IT leadership email/phone	CTO, IT Director, VPs	Direct notification for high-severity incidents
Zoom Bridge	IT incident team	Live coordination during active P1

Vendor support portal	Vendor technical team	Open vendor cases; relay updates to IC
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Communication Cadence

Time	Action	Owner	Channel(s)
T+0	P1 declared; INC ticket created	First Responder	SummitDesk
T+5	Bridge call opened; team assembled	IC	Slack #it-major-incidents
T+10	#it-help awareness post: "We are aware of an issue with [service]. Investigating."	Comms Lead	Slack #it-help
T+15	IT leadership notified (IT Director, CTO if warranted)	IC / Comms Lead	Direct Slack DM or phone
T+15	Status page updated: Investigating	Comms Lead	status.summitit.com
T+30	First formal update to IT leadership with preliminary assessment	Comms Lead	Email to IT Director + affected VPs
T+30	Status page updated with more detail: identified cause or ongoing investigation note	Comms Lead	status.summitit.com
T+60	Second update to IT leadership; Slack #announcements post if outage >1 hour	Comms Lead	Email + Slack #announcements
Every 60 min	Ongoing stakeholder updates until resolved	Comms Lead	Email + status page

Resolution	Resolution notice - all channels; all-staff post if outage was >2 hours	IC + Comms Lead	All channels below
T+2 biz days	PIR meeting scheduled	IC	Calendar invite
T+5 biz days	PIR document published in SummitDesk knowledge base	IC	SummitDesk KB

Status Page Management (<https://status.summitit.com>)

Summit IT uses a hosted status page (StatusPage.io-compatible) to communicate service health.

Updating the Status Page

1. Log into <https://status.summitit.com/admin> with IT admin credentials.
2. Click **+ New Incident**.
3. Fill in: - **Incident name:** Brief, plain-language title (e.g., "Email service disruption") - **Status:** Investigating / Identified / Monitoring / Resolved - **Affected components:** Select all impacted services (e.g., Email, VPN, Authentication) - **Message body:** Use templates below
4. Select notification options: **Email subscribers** and **Slack webhook** (auto-posts to #status-updates).
5. Click **Create Incident**.

Updating an Existing Incident

1. In the status page admin, find the open incident.
2. Click **Add Update**.
3. Update the status field and add a message.
4. Save and post - subscribers are notified automatically.

Resolving the Incident on the Status Page

1. Add a final update with status **Resolved**.
 2. All affected components return to **Operational**.
 3. Subscribers receive an automated resolution email.
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Communication Templates

Template 1: Initial Awareness Post (Slack #it-help - T+10)

[IT NOTICE] We are aware of an issue affecting [service name, e.g., "Microsoft 365 email"]. Our team is actively investigating. We will provide an update as soon as possible.

For urgent assistance: call +1 (800) 555-7866 or email servicedesk@summitit.com.
Status updates: <https://status.summitit.com>

- Summit IT Service Desk

Template 2: Status Page - Investigating (T+15)

Incident name: [Service] disruption - under investigation **Status:** Investigating **Message:**

We are currently investigating an issue affecting [service name]. Users may experience [brief impact description, e.g., "inability to send or receive email"]. Our team has been engaged and is actively working to identify the root cause. Next update: [time].

Template 3: IT Leadership Notification Email (T+30)

Subject: [P1 ACTIVE] IT Incident - [Service Name] - INC-[#####]

Team,

We have declared a Priority 1 incident for [service name].

Incident details:

- Ticket: INC-[#####]
- Start time: [HH:MM ET]
- Impact: [Brief description - how many users, what they cannot do]
- Status: Investigating / Root cause identified as [X] / Fix in progress

Current assessment:

[2-3 sentences on what we know so far - no speculation]

Estimated resolution time: [ETA if known, or "Under investigation - next update at HH:MM"]

Incident Commander: [Name]

Bridge call: <https://summitit.zoom.us/j/999001001>

Next update: [HH:MM ET]

- [Comms Lead Name], Summit IT

Template 4: User-Facing Update (Slack #announcements or Email - T+60+)

[IT UPDATE - HH:MM ET] - INC-[#####]

Service: [Service Name]

Status: [Investigating / Root Cause Identified / Monitoring fix]

Impact: [Brief plain-language description]

What we know: [1-2 sentences - factual, no speculation]

What we're doing: [1 sentence on action being taken]

Estimated resolution: [ETA or "We will provide an update by HH:MM ET"]

Thank you for your patience.

- Summit IT Service Desk | status.summitit.com

Template 5: Resolution Announcement

Slack #it-help and #announcements:

[RESOLVED - HH:MM ET] - INC-#####

[Service name] has been fully restored as of [HH:MM ET].

Duration: [start time] - [end time] ([X hours Y minutes])

Impact: [Brief description of who was affected]

Root cause: [Concise, non-technical description]

We apologize for the disruption. If you continue to experience issues, please contact us: +1 (800) 555-7866 | servicedesk@summitit.com | Slack: #it-help

A post-incident review will be completed within 5 business days.

- Summit IT Service Desk

Resolution email to IT leadership:

Subject: [RESOLVED] IT Incident - [Service Name] - INC-#####

Team,

We have resolved the P1 incident affecting [service name].

Resolution summary:

- Resolved at: [HH:MM ET]
- Total duration: [X hours Y minutes]
- Users affected: [estimate]
- Root cause: [1-2 sentences - technical but accessible]
- Fix applied: [What was done]

A formal Post-Incident Review (PIR) will be scheduled within 2 business days and the PIR document will be published within 5 business days.

Incident Commander: [Name]

Ticket: INC-#####

- [Comms Lead Name] on behalf of the Summit IT team

Stakeholder Contact List

Stakeholder	Role	Notification Trigger	Contact
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Gretchen Holloway	IT Director	All P1s - T+15 min	gretchen.holloway@summitit.com / +1 (720) 555-0192
Nathan Burkett	CISO	All security-related P1s - immediately	nathan.burkett@summitit.com / +1 (720) 555-0117
Patricia Vang	CTO	P1 affecting >200 users or security breach	patricia.vang@summitit.com / +1 (720) 555-0188
Finance VP	Finance VP	Finance systems outage (email, ERP)	finance-vp@summitit.com
HR Director	HR Director	HR systems outage; any security breach involving employee data	hr-director@summitit.com
Legal Counsel	General Counsel	Security breach with data exposure; regulatory notification	legal@summitit.com
All Staff	Employees	P1 lasting >60 minutes affecting all users	all-staff@summitit.com (use sparingly)

Post-Incident Review (PIR) Process

PIR Meeting Agenda (60 minutes)

Time	Topic
0-5 min	Welcome; confirm attendees; recap incident timeline
5-15 min	Root cause walkthrough by Technical Lead
15-25 min	What went well
25-40 min	What went wrong / gaps identified
40-55 min	Action items - assign owner and due date for each
55-60 min	Next steps; PIR doc publication date

PIR Document Structure

The PIR document is published as a SummitDesk knowledge base article tagged **Post-Incident Review**:

- 1. Incident summary (title, date, duration, services affected, user impact)
- 2. Timeline (minute-by-minute log)
- 3. Root cause analysis (technical and contributing factors)
- 4. What went well
- 5. What went wrong / improvement areas
- 6. Action items (table: item, owner, due date, status)
- 7. Appendix: INC ticket link; vendor case numbers; bridge call recording link

Action Item Tracking

All PIR action items must be: - Logged as sub-tasks in the original INC ticket or as new REQ tickets linked to the PIR. - Reviewed at the next monthly IT Operations Review. - Closed or escalated within the agreed due date.

Do's and Don'ts During a P1

Do	Do not
Send regular updates even when there is no new technical progress	Go silent for >60 minutes without an update
Keep user-facing language simple and jargon-free	Use technical details (error codes, system names) in all-staff communications
Direct users to the status page for self-service updates	Tell users to "just wait" without an ETA
Report externally requested ETAs to the IC first	Promise resolution times without IC approval
Notify legal/CISO immediately for any data exposure	Speculate on whether data was exposed without SOC/CISO confirmation
Log all decisions in the SummitDesk ticket	Communicate resolution before verifying with the Technical Lead